just another job. But, for some reason, Murthy had put me in that seat often, maybe because he liked the way my voice came through the speakers.

So, on 2 February 1968, the day when Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was to dedicate TERLS to the United Nations, I was asked to do the honours. I was not very amused as this would mean that I may not get to meet Mrs Gandhi who would witness the launch of a sounding rocket and get introduced to the scientists at TERLS, while I will be cocooned in the control room on a campus across the road. But I agreed when Murthy insisted.

Then Murthy said something that made me happy: ten minutes before the lift-off, the prime minister, accompanied by Vikram Sarabhai, will visit the control room to see the countdown. Murthy told me that the controller should look important and should go about his job unmindful of the Prime Minister coming in. On the day, I wore a suit to work and decided to look important.

The countdown progressed smoothly, and at T-minus ten minutes, the door behind me opened and Sarabhai walked in with Mrs Gandhi. I had not forgotten Murthy's instruction, but I involuntarily I rose from my chair. But before I could stand up to greet the important visitors, a hand pressed on my shoulder.

'Sit still,' whispered Sarabhai.

I sat like a school boy and continued with the countdown procedures, my mind racing on whether I would get to shake hands with the Prime Minister. Soon they walked out, and the rest of the countdown went on well.

Soon after the lift-off, once my job was done, I rushed out and asked a driver to take me immediately to the other side of the TERLS campus where scientists were lining up to meet Mrs Gandhi. I was the last to join the line and, by default, the first one to be introduced to the Prime Minister by Sarabhai.

Some of the trials were successes in the first attempt. A payload recovery system, the brainchild of mechanical engineer V Sudhakar, is a